

KANADOKU

Before Kanjidoku

かなドク

Hiragana and katakana sudoku

5 puzzles from the book

There are 100 in it.



MIND QUESTS

How to play

Sudoku, with kana instead of numbers. Every row, every column and every marked region must hold each kana of the set exactly once. Nothing else is different, and no puzzle in this book needs a guess: every grid can be finished by reasoning alone.

Two ways to make progress

Look at an empty cell and cross off every kana already in its row, its column and its region. If one kana survives, it belongs there.

Or take one kana and one region, and ask where it can go. If every cell but one is blocked, it belongs in the cell that is left.

Those two ideas will finish every puzzle in this book. The grids were built that way on purpose.

The sizes

The book runs from 4x4 up to 9x9. Five and seven are prime numbers and have no rectangular boxes to divide into, so those grids use irregular regions instead, tinted so you can see their shapes. There are 21 of them.

Sizes climb through each part of the book and never shrink. They start again at the beginning of each part, because when the alphabet changes you are a beginner again.

The word at the end

Some cells in every grid are shaded and numbered, and they start empty. Solve the grid, read those cells in order, and you have a real Japanese word built out of the kana you have just spent twenty minutes with. There are 548 shaded cells in this book and 133 words hidden behind them.

The puzzle is the lock. The word is what is inside it.

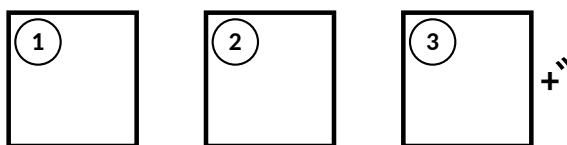
Three kinds of box

A shaded, numbered box is a cell you solve for. Read the kana out of the grid and write it in.

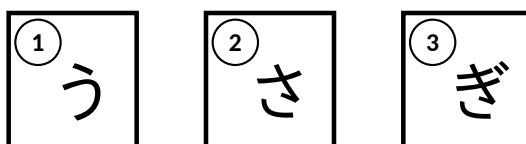
A box with a mark beside it wants that kana plus the mark. The grid holds き; with the mark it becomes ぎ. This is not a trick: だ really is た with a mark, and Japanese does this constantly. Part one has a short section that teaches the marks before any answer needs one.

A grey box is already filled in for you. The grid cannot hold a small kana or a long bar, so those are printed. You will meet at most one in a hiragana puzzle and two in katakana, where ー is a fact of life.

Puzzle 1, worked through



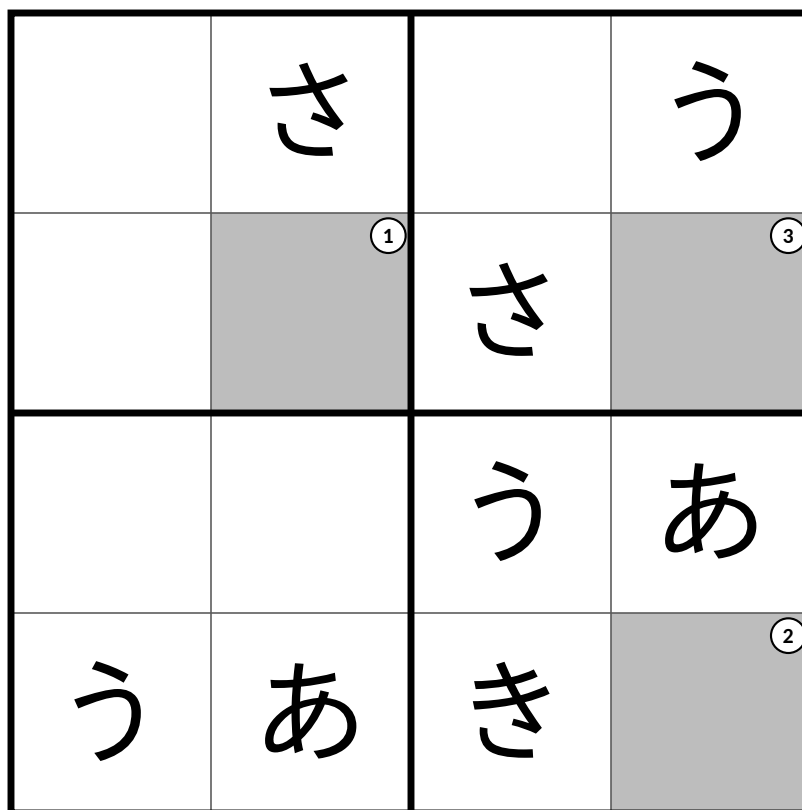
Solve the grid, then read the shaded cells in order.



usagi · rabbit

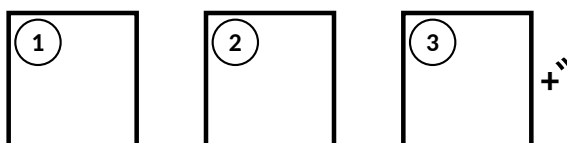
あ行, か行 **and** さ行

4×4 • boxes



あ	う	き	さ
a	u	ki	sa

THE WORD



あ行, か行 **and** さ行 to begin with. Every kana in the grid comes from these, and the rest of the alphabet arrives over the next few puzzles.

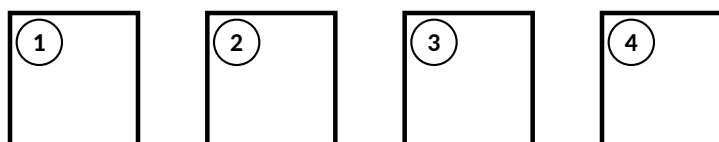
Something to drink

5×5 · jigsaw



の	へ	み	む	も
no	he	mi	mu	mo

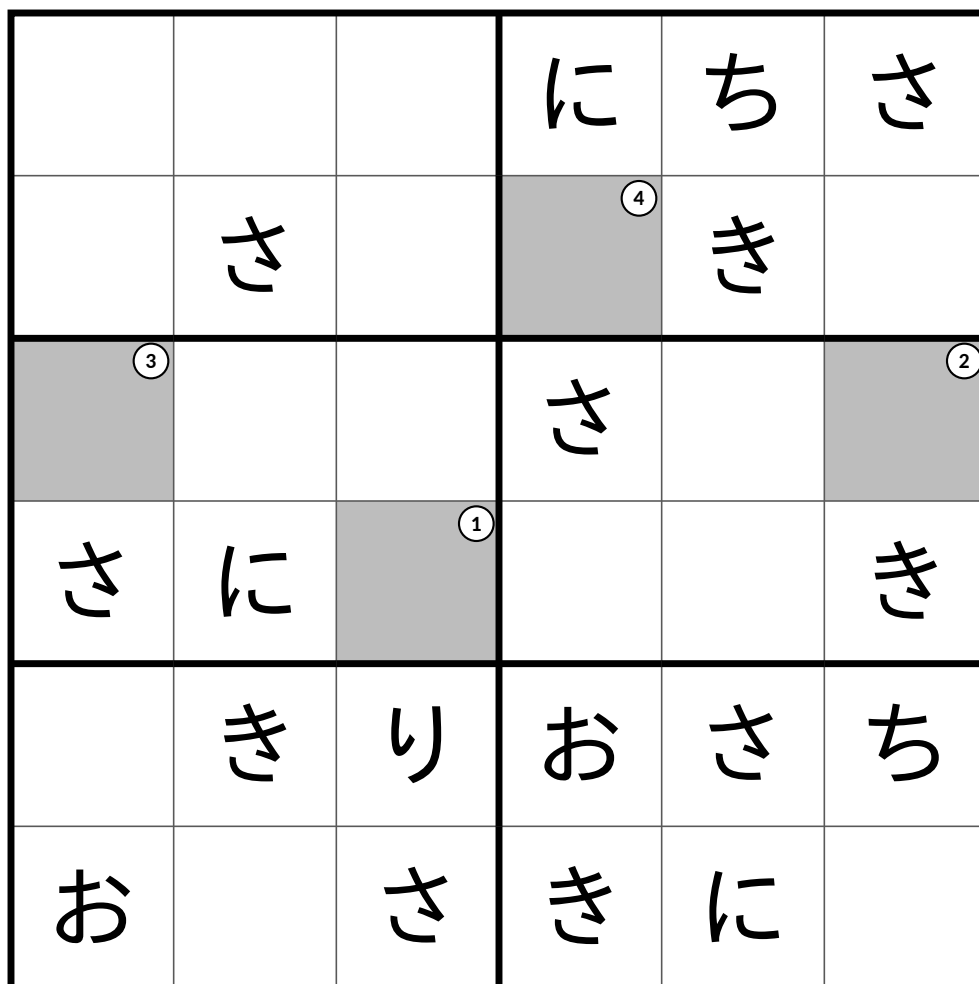
THE WORD



This one has no straight divisions to lean on. Work from the rows and columns first and let the regions catch up.

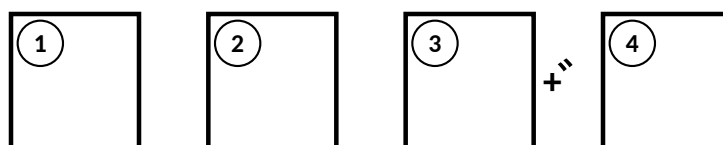
さ・き・ち

6×6 • boxes



お	き	さ	ち	に	り
o	ki	sa	chi	ni	ri

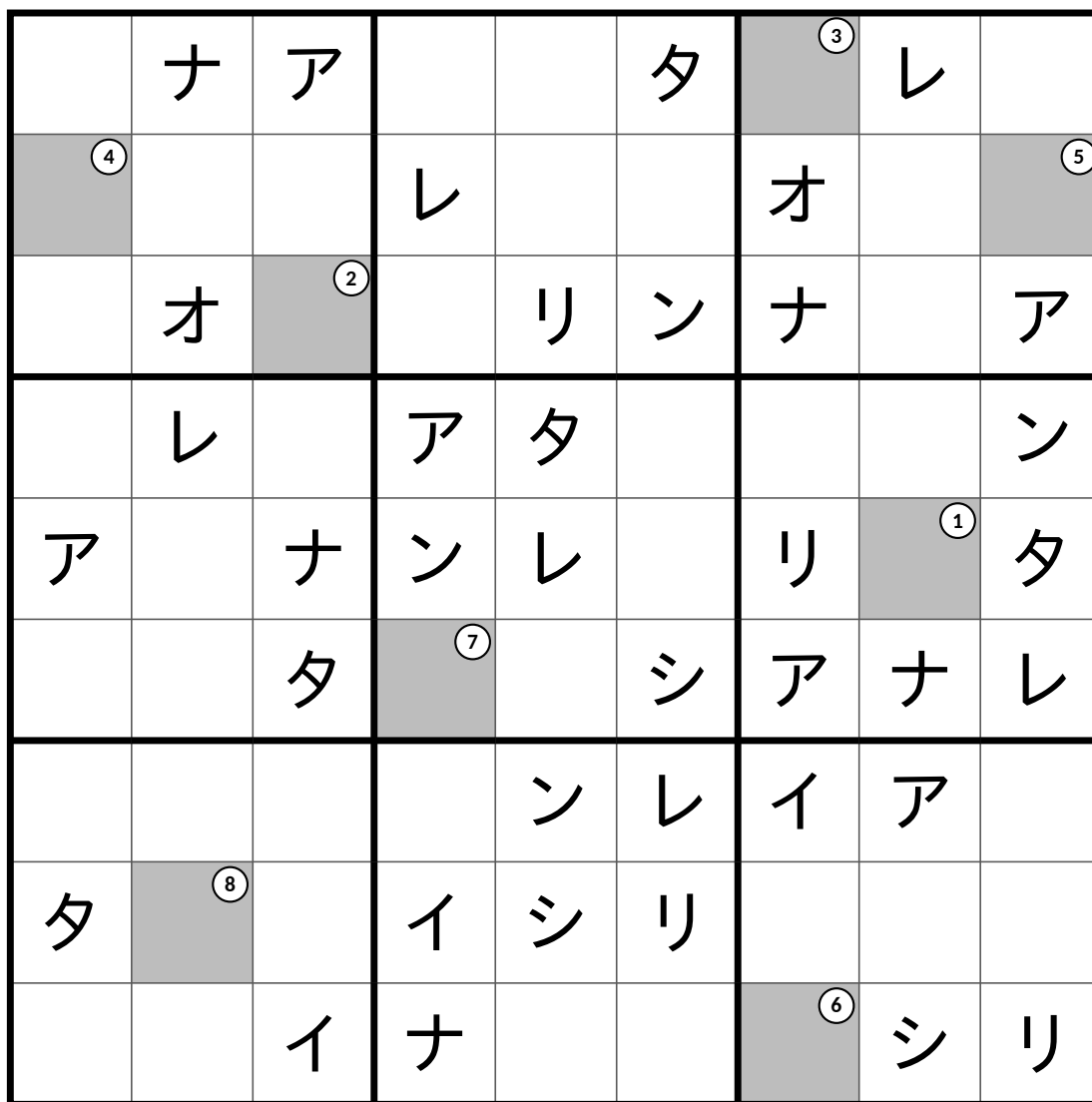
THE WORD



き has two crossbars, さ has one, and ち is さ turned over. Watch which way the tail goes.

Orange and Italy

9×9 • boxes



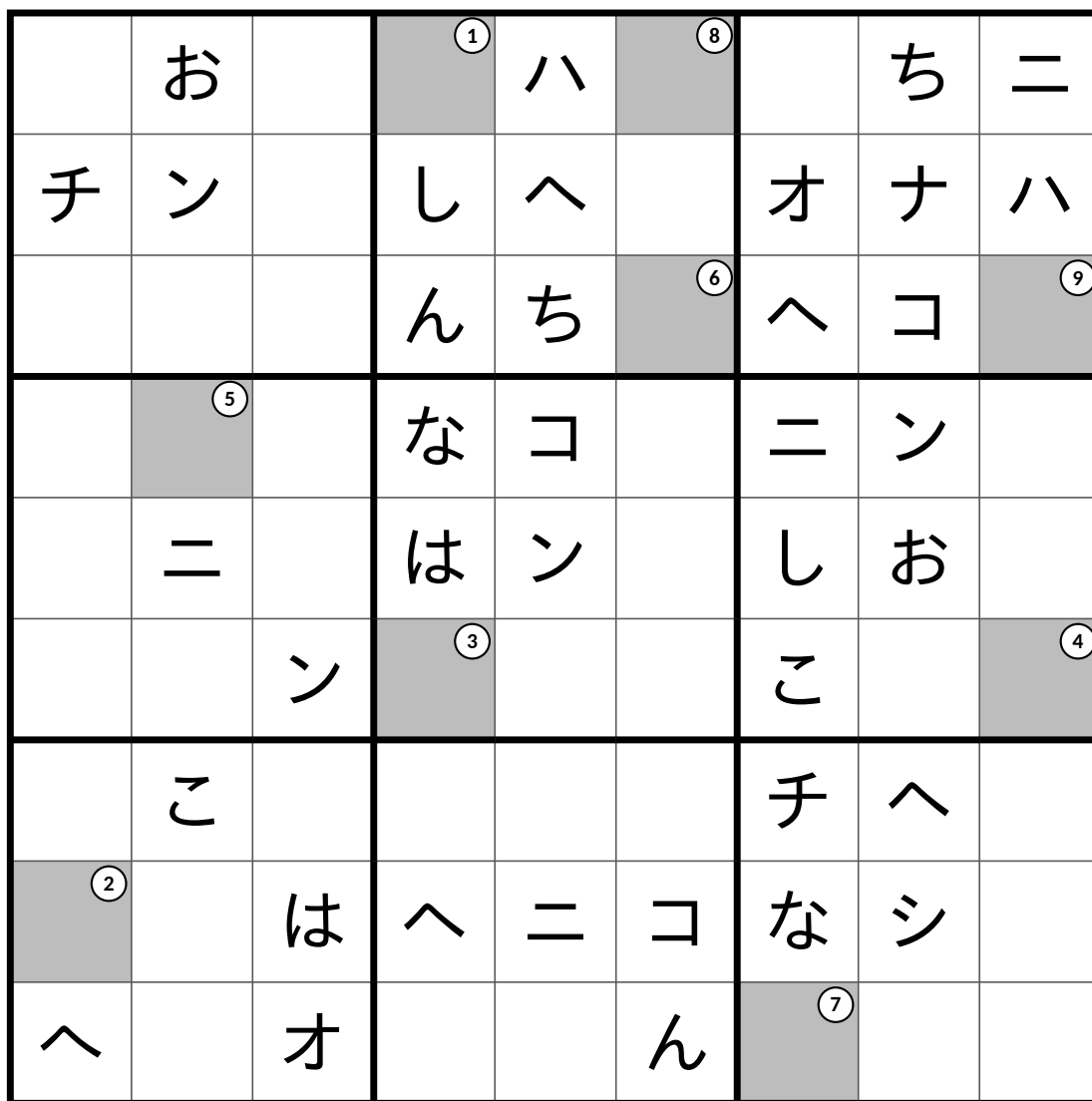
ア	イ	オ	シ	タ	ナ	リ	レ	ン
a	i	o	shi	ta	na	ri	re	n

THE WORDS

1. ① ② ③ ④ +"
2. ⑤ ⑥ ⑦ ⑧

Hello and a story, told

9×9 • boxes



お	オ	こ	コ	し	シ	ち	チ	な	ナ	に	ニ	は	ハ	へ	ヘ	ん	ン
o		ko		shi		chi		na		ni		ha		he		n	

THE WORDS

1. ① ② ③ ④ ⑤
2. ⑥ ⑦ ⑧ ⑨

The last kana is は, not わ, even though it is pronounced wa. It is the grammatical particle, frozen in place.

き	さ	あ	う
あ	う ^①	さ	き ^③
さ	き	う	あ
う	あ	き	さ ^②

1. あ行, か行 AND さ行

usagi

うさぎ rabbit

も ^③	の ^④	へ	む	み
へ	も	み ^②	の	む
む	み	の	も	へ
み	む	も	へ	の ^①
の	へ	む	み	も

11. SOMETHING TO DRINK

nomimono

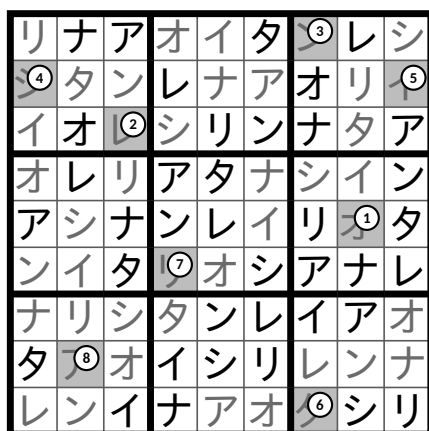
のみもの something to drink

り	お	き	に	ち	さ
ち	さ	に	り ^④	き	お
き ^③	り	ち	さ	お	に ^②
さ	に	お ^①	ち	り	き
に	き	り	お	さ	ち
お	ち	さ	き	に	り

16. さ・き・ち

onigiri

おにぎり rice ball



78. ORANGE AND ITALY

orenji

オレンジ orange

itaria

イタリア Italy



97. HELLO AND A STORY, TOLD

konnichiwa

こんにちは hello

ohanashi

おはなし a story, told

Writing it out

The sixteen kana these five puzzles lean on hardest, each with a model to copy. Japanese is written from the top down and from the left across, so start at the top left of each shape and work down. The book has pages like this for all 92.

お

o

き

ki

さ

sa

し

shi

ち

chi

に

ni

へ

he

り

ri

ア

a

イ

i

オ

o

シ

shi

タ

ta

ナ

na

リ

ri

ン

n

There are ninety-five more

Those five came out of *Kanadoku: Before Kanjidoku*, which holds 100 of them and teaches both alphabets from nothing in the course of solving them.

100

grids

92

kana taught

133

words hidden

The book runs in three parts. Hiragana first, one row of the alphabet at a time, so the fifth puzzle uses kana the first four taught you. Then katakana, from nothing again. Then both at once, which is how Japanese is actually written. At the back there are solutions with every word translated, the full chart of both alphabets, a page for writing out each of the 92, and every word the book hides, listed in the order you meet it.

Four books follow it, playing the same game with kanji, graded to the Japanese Language Proficiency Test. This one comes first because the kanji volumes assume you can read the kana around them.

PLEASE PASS IT ON

This sampler is free. Share it, print it, hand it round a class: teachers are welcome to it and need not ask. The one condition is that it travels whole and unchanged, and that nobody sells it.

KANJIDOKU.NET for the rest of the series, and the other samplers